

TKTKTK

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

V., the protagonist;

M., the object of V.'s affection, among other things;

J. and K., V.'s girlfriends;

C. and D., M.'s girlfriends;

B., M.'s ex;

X., V.'s college writing mentor and professor;

Aurora Mattia, who needs no introduction

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EXCERPTS FROM JOHN GALL

I. IF SOMETHING ISN'T WORKING, DON'T KEEP DOING IT. DO SOMETHING ELSE INSTEAD. DO ALMOST ANYTHING ELSE.

19 August 2023

She was always looking for someone to obsess over—a trans woman, preferably. This time it was M. She wore a dress, skimpy and too-tight, for M., and alliteratively she thought of Mitski. *You know I wore this dress for you.* She couldn't remember the last time she wore a dress for somebody. It felt like the first time, though of course it wasn't. But she liked it if it felt like the first time. And wasn't it, if she didn't remember? That was one of the blessings of poor memory, post-viral and weed-addled. Things could be new. And she liked to make statements with her body.¹ The night before, M. had called her very pretty and she had called M. strikingly beautiful. Strikingly beautiful. *What does that mean*, M. had said. What does that mean.

¹ One time, she had governed her progesterone cycle by the rhythm of a lover's northward peregrination. They hadn't liked that. *There's more to life than fucking.* She knew there was more to life than fucking. Progesterone was a tool and why couldn't she mark and manipulate her body as she wished? Make it useful for something. Make it speak. She resented it when too much was made of her use of her own body. She wanted to be the sort of woman who used hormones in this way—it was about her, not so much the other person in the equation. That didn't make it better, but still, she knew there was more to life than fucking.

What does it mean? M. was probably what you would call “traditionally beautiful” but that wasn’t it. She could have meditated on M.’s face with easy pleasure. Witnessing M.’s face was a physiological event in a statistically unusual way. If a million copies of her were locked into a million tiny rooms and subjected to sensory deprivation torture—each one made to gaze upon nothing but one of a million different faces—she thought that the version of herself trapped with M.’s face would take a long time to reach nervous breakdown. She wanted to look into M.’s eyes.² She was wearing the dress to the party for her self, the self that wanted to be observed in general, but more than anything that self wanted to be observed by M. She imagined that M. would call *her* strikingly beautiful, and then *she* could ask M. what that meant, and M. would say “It means I want to kiss you,” and she would say “That’s what it means for me too.”

The thought of actually kissing made her queasy. Maybe she knew there was more to life than fucking, maybe she didn’t, but either way she didn’t fuck that much. Actually it wasn’t even the fear of fucking. She felt ambivalent about passionate love. Maybe love is like the rain, as she had thought for years with naive faith, but *ipso facto* sometimes it’s like a flood. Her own existing romantic commitments were delicate things. She was scared. Of course she would have kissed M. in a heartbeat. But M. wasn’t likely to kiss her, so she could content

² When she did look into M.’s eyes it was overwhelming. M. weaved her head from side to side to disrupt eye contact when it was too much, as it often was. She had picked up the habit. She was autistic, too, but more than that the eyes opened a channel V. was scared of. Too much desire, too fast. Bottomless. M. would look into her eyes and see it and what then?

herself with this distance, which was a form of pleasure of its own, and romantic infatuation with its destructive potential could simmer, be contained and transformed. At least that's what she told herself. Deleuze and Guattari say, of courtly love, that "the slightest caress may be as strong as an orgasm; orgasm is a mere fact, a rather deplorable one, in relation to desire in pursuit of its principle."

That night in her too-tight dress she decisively beat M. at ping pong and she beamed to think of it still. She had shaped herself to M.'s play—more than that she had asserted herself as her own surface for interaction, her own pattern of motion and impact. Their bodies had spoken to each other. And she won.

II. IF YOU'RE NOT AWARE THAT YOU HAVE A PROBLEM, HOW CAN YOU CALL FOR HELP?

22 August 2023

Perhaps her strategy of containment was working too well. That morning, M. sent her a video–selfie angle, in a car, wearing only a bra and shorts and holding a joint. It was the “smoking before work strat—so that my clothes don’t smell like weed.”³ This was, she thought, a very funny situation. M. was aware, in a limited sense, of her infatuation. What was M. thinking? It was a pleasant terrain. A limited way of being with M. Her inner construct of M., at least. She heard voices in her head most days—sometimes terrible and intrusive, other times gentle and playful. She liked to hear M., though most of the time when prompted she said something to the effect of INSUFFICIENT DATA, which was true in more ways than one. She certainly didn’t have as much data about M. as she would have liked. Wasn’t this book a way of formalizing and intensifying the practice of data collection?

³ Like M., she did not have a particularly healthy relationship with cannabis. As she wrote her throat and lungs were irritated and painful from the day before. Once, she had sat on her knees while M. regulated the voltage on a power supply connected to the cartridge of weed in her hands. “Tell me when,” M. said. That this felt like a largely sexless exercise—that she recognized only well after that fact that it *could* have been, probably *would* have been in many situations sexually charged—was, once again, amusing.

Anyway: containment, what was M. thinking. Presumably she was thinking that she wanted to share something funny and V. could be trusted to be a big girl and not jerk off about it. And indeed jerking off registered as a possibility only in the way that she felt like she had to register all plausible possibilities, for completeness's sake. Orgasm would, yes, have felt deplorable. There's not going to be a fucking book, she thought. I'm supposed to be horny for this girl. Abstractedly she thought that for someone who claimed to know that there was more to life than fucking she had certainly bee-lined to those considerations when confronted with the simple fact of M. in a bra. That's the book. It's a Bildungsroman about learning there's more to life than fucking. As it stood, she felt a fairly impersonal aesthetic appreciation, which did, nevertheless, insist upon itself; but mainly she felt quite distant from the too-tight dress and irrepressible, spontaneous desire to be seen that way by M.

This was probably good, though boring. She thought that friendships, when they are working well, are boring. Boring could be a good thing. Her very rich inner life and fragmented psyche contained a good number of actively suicidal parts at any given time, and romance often made them more suicidal, so a simple commitment to mutual flourishing could be nice, even with M. She thought that was what M. saw in her, much more than the potential for sex. Early on in their friendship, during the encounters that cemented their bond as closer than most, M. had discussed at length her traumatic adolescence and autopoietic emergence therefrom. V. thought she was a pretty good listener, though she often struggled to respond. M. had told her:

I have made a lot of friends over the last uh ... 8 months and tbh I have had a hard time still implicating quite a lot of my inner experience into those relationships and it feels like things kind of just clicked with you in a way they haven't with anyone else thus far ... C. [M.'s girlfriend, one of two] and I were talking about this actually they said they could tell I had a very different shape of endearment to you vs. other friendships they've seen me make.

She liked to think of the shape of endearment. M. had listened as well—was quickly becoming one of her closest friends—she cared for M. as a person in a simple, straightforward way. But: M. had popped into her head. You're falling in love with me because I'm a theorycel. Put that in the book. She could not say no to M., even when she deepened the poisoning of her prose with Discord-Zoomerspeak. There are other reasons, she told M. Yes. But it's relevant that I'm a theorycel.

With a sigh, she acknowledged: she was partly falling in love with M. because she was a theorycel, which was essentially to say she was falling in love with M. because she read a lot, in a vaguely left way. M. gave her assignments, and she needed assignments. Gilles Deleuze

and Felix Guattari,⁴ John Gall, Donna J. Haraway, Gilbert Simondon, Phillip K. Dick, Georges Bataille, Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela. She began to think in terms of machines. She quoted Systemantics in a letter to her girlfriend J. Our relationship is a system of systems.

V. had read too—she had studied political philosophy at Yale—but in a cynical, tortured way. She had been an undocumented immigrant since 2003 and a DACA recipient since the early 2010s. She felt that, more than a child of either the United States or her home country, she was a child of empire, shaped and honed for its purposes. The Ivy League (or its immediate peers) had been decided for her by the logic of financial aid: as a non-resident alien, she could not claim standard scholarships or even loans, could not claim in-state tuition in her deep-red home state. Only certain very rich institutions offered aid to the barely legal. So she became the perfect aspiring technocrat, because at the time she could not imagine anything else, saw it as the only way out of an abusive household. She joined her high school debate team. Once, she won a national tournament by arguing for limited, nuanced airstrikes in Libya. College came and with it a notional increase in freedom of action but still she couldn't see anything else. She studied grand strategy, which at Yale was a prestigious and gatekept area of study—the CIA, State Department, NSA track. Her senior thesis advisor was the founder of the Federalist Society; she wrote about medieval and early modern English legal

⁴ The latter, M. insisted, was a trans woman. She felt this way about Søren Kierkegaard. This was a common enough thing among the trans women she knew—Kurt Cobain, so on—but with M. it felt special to both have arrived at intellectual heroines in this way.

ideology.⁵ She reached some mildly interesting conclusions about originalism as a legal philosophy and felt, together with the sweaty satisfaction of completing a monumental intellectual task—any intellectual task—a faint sadness. She liked to joke that it was a good thing she had been illegal because otherwise she’d have joined the CIA. She had, M. fondly liked to say, “operator brain.”⁶

M. had been a lonely kid—U.S. born, child of deeply evangelical doctors—and, as she put it, “intellectually based [slang]” from the age of 14. In discussing her earlier life she always returned to the loneliness. But in that loneliness she had read prodigiously, and unlike V. she did not have to get into the Ivy League. She read to make sense of the world; V. had read mostly to traverse it and act on it in the pursuit of meritocratic achievement. Marxism for aspiring bloodthirsty yuppies. M.’s life was marked by severe discontinuities of self and experience, but continuously she read, and for reasons she felt good about.

V. had mostly abandoned reading since college. There had been one major intellectual development in her life since she graduated—yoga—and she read a little for that, because she had started (and would eventually drop out of) teacher training, and there had been a curriculum. She needed a curriculum.

⁵ “You should be careful with Kantorowicz, [her most important source,]” the founder of the Federalist Society had told her, “he was substantially implicated in fascism.” She nodded serenely.

⁶ Once she and her girlfriend J. had a small fight over V.’s stated desire to have been born in the Soviet Union and joined the Spetsnaz, trans womanhood be damned.

Really more than a curriculum she needed a worldview. M. had said:

The virtual governor does not exist, it is not a body, and it is not simply information. Like that's the fusion of Spinoza and cybernetics and Guattari I'm after.

She wanted to be after a fusion, too. They had met at a party; a mutual friend,⁷ bringing her to someone else, had said "Valentina. Philosophy!" by way of introduction and M. had swept in and carried her away. "I think all Leninists should be Machiavellians," she had said, drunk. "That's interesting," M. replied, and continued, "Are you a Leninist?" M. thought she was very interesting in general. She met other people that night, had other conversations, but the only thing she remembered now was M.–M. interrogating her worldview, M. looking at her—mostly M. looking at her. It felt new to be observed and probed by a mind like M.'s. And maybe it actually was.

She knew then in an embodied, intuitive sense—words would come later—that she wanted M., one way or another, to be important to her. Ever since she had abandoned her intellectual life, fleeing from it as she fled from so much during her early transition, life had gone on

⁷ Three years prior, across the still widening chasm of the pandemic, she had matched with a couple on Tinder. A threesome had not materialized, but a Communist book club had. She attended once and said something mildly negative about Mao Zedong, which was met with muted, but unmistakable, opprobrium. Nevertheless, she made enough of an impression to be invited to a party when Snapchat revealed, with its friendly, Bitmoji surveillance state, that in the present V. lived 2 minutes away from her Marxist acquaintances.

with a constant, muted scream in the background. She needed to be writing. She needed to be thinking. M. spurred her to both. Nabokov said the good thing about having written a book is that it's there on your shelf, you can take it down and think I have written a book. She felt that way about merely having a creative project. It had been four days since that first sentence had come to her and since then the screaming in her mind had been almost entirely absent. She thought of M. and smiled.

III. THE FUNCTION OF A SYSTEM IS WHAT IT DOES

6 July 2023

This story was also about Aurora Mattia. She had been obsessed with her first. Dear X., she wrote a college professor,

Life has been stressful and frankly stupid in some ways, but I read *The Fifth Wound* and it was like some kind of awakening, so that's been an upside. I kind of want to write an *I Love Dick*-style thing about it but oh, I languish as my programming job sucks out the vital juices from my brain, etc. I hope she signs my book and doesn't remember who I am.

Well, Aurora, what can I say? The time has come, and it's not about you. But you're in it. I fell in love with you a little bit—sorry.

She was feeling archival. An excerpt from the abandoned “I Love Dick-style” literary project:

Dear Aurora,

Do you remember me?

In *The Fifth Wound* you talk about how the passage of time revises our understanding of the past. The meaning of our constellation of instants is an ever-shifting thing. I have been thinking recently of a seminar held on the occasion of the Windham-Campbell Prize and led by one of its winners. There we were. I had written some garbage—dutiful MFA prose—and unfortunately I have forgotten what you brought.

When I read, you said: "The sentences are good, but they reiterate the same thought."

When you read, I said something stupid about your delivery—the way you said "right now"—my memory is blurry because I was flustered and wavering in and out of dissociation—I was *flustered*. The prizewinner (an Australian? New Zealander?) didn't know what to make of it or seem to think it was appropriate and neither did you and this haunts me. When I wrote "do

you remember me?" I almost appended "(I hope you don't)."

The memory has lingered and burned—survived mostly in fits of shame. A mantra: *I was weird about a trans woman*. As I read *The Fifth Wound*, it hovered beside me always, deepening and deepening a (certainly parasocial) attachment. It hovered and hovered and eventually the alchemy of the book absorbed it and transformed it. You know desire so much better than I do and thanks to your writing I know it now better than I did. Desire can give life a shape, a logic, a *nomos*. It can make facts more intelligible. It can deepen the meaning of a string of instants lodged, through the years, in a mind. It allows me to understand, and say:

I did not know myself as a woman at all. And you were so beautiful. And your voice was so mesmerizing. I could have listened to you talk for hours. That is what I was feeling.

Beyond a beautiful, glitching map of desire, Aurora had given her something very concrete: Townes Van Zandt. During a recent depressive episode, when she could apparently do nothing but fester and sit together with the screaming in her head, she had managed to

compile a playlist of every song mentioned in *The Fifth Wound* so at least she was listening to something instead of just rotting.⁸ She listened to Townes Van Zandt explore the possibilities of beautiful forlornness over and over and over again. Attention is the beginning of devotion, Mary Oliver had said. Going on long walks in the summer heat, she listened to her playlist and thought about *The Fifth Wound*. She cultivated obsession like it was a flowering plant.

“Certainly parasocial.” She thought this was not quite it. When she looked at Aurora’s Instagram she did not feel like Aurora was her friend. In fact she hardly looked; it felt like an intrusion. She believed—and felt very insecure about this belief—that there could be something beautiful and generative in this kind of detached obsession. For her it was a technical term—a mechanism. She did not seek out obsessive desire. It came to her, willing or not. To write about someone—even just to think about someone—is to turn them into a symbol, or rather a collection of symbols, a system of symbols. Why not make art out of the inevitable?

And wasn’t there a certain beauty to the encounter? Is desire such an embarrassing thing? Sleepwalking through her college years in a fog of depersonalization, she had interacted with a trans woman and found her beautiful. She had been so uncomfortable with desire in those days—a libidinal automaton, hypersexual and emotionally careless, sex more about mechanical achievement than any kind of sensuality.⁹ To

⁸ TKTK provide this one way or another probably a list TKTK

⁹ “Making sure your partner orgasms,” she had said as a 20-year-old “cishet man”, “is a feminist requirement.”

be flustered—simply flustered—by a beautiful woman was essentially foreign. Didn't the encounter—awkward as it was—engender what you could call a stumbling expression of her own womanhood? Couldn't she rewrite its personal meaning, transmute it into something else?

For her, obsession created a complex system within the psyche and the field of sensory awareness. She did not want to write more about her trauma, but she was traumatized, severely; her inner experience often lacked a boundary; she did not know who she was; if she was anything she was a void, or at best a collection of fragments.¹⁰ Aurora and M. existed as constructs within that experience, but they were distinct. She made them distinct with devotion and distance.¹¹ She knew that when she formed a boundary, when she constructed coherence, they would be a part of her but on the outside of that boundary. She would not be Aurora or anyone else. In a mysterious way obsession stabilized the dynamics of the system. The symbol-systems she made for herself became surfaces for interaction and feedback, became control mechanisms.

¹⁰ The first time she read "These fragments I have shored against my ruins" in *The Waste Land*, she wept. T.S. Eliot stands for TransSexual Eliot.

¹¹ You could maintain a kind of distance from someone, she thought, while remaining quite close. This was irrelevant in the case of Aurora—the distance was simple and straightforward—but with M. it mattered to her greatly. She was nervous about what she was doing, about this symbol-construction, real-time mining of a relationship for literary material. But if anything literary obsession neutralized real obsession; at an embodied level she felt closer to M., more able to relate freely, since she had begun this process of distancing and containment.

13 August 2023

She went to see Death Grips in Asheville with M., some of M.'s extended romantic orbit,¹² and a group of wholesome Southern boys who were very normal—she wrote this earnestly—about trans women. This book is not trying to say anything interesting about music, but for the record she did not particularly care for the performance. M., her girlfriend D., and V. stood immobile while the crowd undulated and moshed. She felt a kinship. In front of them, someone who was on drugs with which V. was not familiar tried to meet their gaze in an intense, unblinking way. She was glad for the boys.

On the way home M. got carsick and laid her head in V.'s lap and held her hand. M.'s thumb moved over the inside of her thumb, the webbing next to it, the edge of her index finger. M.'s hands were very strong.¹³ B. controlled the car stereo; V. asked her to play "I'll Be Here in the Morning" by Townes Van Zandt. She felt happy. The car ride could have gone on forever.

When M. affectionately touched V., as she often did, the person and the symbol-system collided. It was a pleasant collision. Direct input. Data flow into the system. M. believed in the V. who could manage infatuation and physical affection in tandem; she suggested a possible

¹² D. was currently dating M., and though D. did not talk much M. reported she liked V.; B. *had* dated M., and was clearly still obsessed with, even possessive of her. There was maybe something about M., she thought, that invited obsession.

¹³ The closest V. got to actually burning with desire in the presence of M. was when she loaded bullets into a magazine with an ease and speed V. was nowhere close to attaining. V. was probably a better shot, but M. would undoubtedly be of more use in a combat situation. This frustrated her and turned her on.

self-articulation which V. embraced. She did not feel pathetic or yearning; just joy. She had a friend. Desire floated in and out of awareness as a fuzzy background fact and did not hook into her emotional loop. It was pleasant to know that it was in her power to keep desire's embodiment squarely in the realm of unrealized potential.

22 August 2023

She needed to move on but wanted to write a little more about M. The day before they had gone to yoga together and then to M.'s house. M. had said "Do you want to smoke weed? And can I show you electronics projects in an annoying way?" V. didn't think it was possible for her to find that annoying but M. insisted. "I am specifically asking if I can try to be agitating."

M. took the lid off of a device V. found mildly ominous—some kind of electronic hardware with a basin full of water—and told V. to stick her hand in. She flipped a switch and V. felt a tingling all over her hand. Was she being electrocuted? She thought that M. just might mildly electrocute her without warning if she was sure it was harmless. In fact it was an ultrasonic cleaner.

M. grabbed a long PVC pipe with some wires attached and plugged it into the wall. "No sudden movements," she said. "This is a potentially fatal activity." V. did not fully understand the electrical configuration

but when M. touched the tip of the pole—it had a metal clamp—to another object sparks and then flames erupted. Afterwards M. noted that the cables connecting everything were quite hot.

They stuck their hands in a laminating press, pressed it down, and waited to see who bailed out first as the temperature climbed up to 300 degrees Fahrenheit. M. won. That was fine because later it was established that V. could push M. over with ease and M. could not do the same. 1-1.

They took a WiFi signal strength measurement tool outside the house and watched its graph go up and down as they walked around. They saw a large spider. They threw an unripe tomato from the garden at the wall as violently as they could. V. felt that she achieved a greater velocity. “Do you ever think,” she asked, “about the alternate universe where we’re born together in the Soviet Union and join the Spetsnaz?” M. laughed and looked at her.

CURSED DOLL

I. AS LONG AS YOU HAVE A LANGUAGE YOU CAN BECOME AN OBSERVER THROUGH THE EXPERIENCE OF LOVE

24 August 2023

V. caught COVID at that party she was so worked up about. M. did, too. V. was not a gracious host for the virus. She was enraged and scared and full of shame. Her head would be full of screaming for days; very little signal would get through. She entered a period of darkness.¹⁴

27 August 2023

It began to rain. This soothed her. Outside she knew the wind was blowing and she imagined the wetness in the air. Every illness made her think about death and on this lightly gray summer afternoon she felt mostly recovered and quite melancholy. Through her window she saw the crate myrtles swaying—erstwhile bushes turned tree-like through genetic manipulation and a certain pattern (or absence) of pruning—and appreciated their delicate, purple-pink flowers and drooping, parabolic slender branchlets. Almost any window you looked out of in this house, there they were. Crate myrtles.

¹⁴ Darkness and—it must be said—weed gummies.

She liked to watch videos of trains moving through landscapes. Had gotten turned on to them, actually, by the pre-eminent professor of Cold War history at Yale.¹⁵ She felt a kinship that transcended their quite distinct historical positions when he talked about slow TV, related his solitary mornings on the stationary bike as approximately 10 hours of cab-mounted footage transported him through Norway, past the village of Hell, to the Arctic Circle. “It’s great,” he said. “Nothing happens.”

28 August 2023

She wished she had gone out in the rain yesterday. Today was hot and claustrophobic—the voices in her head were screaming—she wanted to be screaming, too. Nature was constantly imposing upon her, personally. First COVID and now the general fact of a summer in the South. She needed to leave the house and could not. She needed more direct data about M. and that was at least a week away. She pouted. And even when she got to see M., what would she say? *I’ve been rotting in my house for about two weeks now. Life is so boring. I’m constantly muttering “I want to kill myself.”*¹⁶ *I’m beginning to think you’re not the answer to all of my problems. I meditated for 12 minutes today and I was in a resting brain state for 41% of that time*

¹⁵ During a manic episode, she had sent this august figure a bizarre e-mail. “I have recently begun transition,” she narrated breathlessly. “I am thinking of my relationship with my father in terms of nuclear deterrence.”

¹⁶ Today she had varied the usual formula and said also “no, death wouldn’t be enough, I need to suffer forever.” She didn’t mean it when she said these things but she didn’t *not* mean it, you know. Depressing. The rococo elaboration on the theme made it worse.

and that isn't even the answer to all my problems. What the fuck. Do you think it needs to be 50%?

II. EVERYTHING SAID IS SAID BY AN OBSERVER

27 August 2023

She had been reading Humberto Maturana and Francisco Varela's *Autopoiesis and Cognition: The Realization of the Living*.¹⁷ It was on the curriculum.¹⁸

Autopoiesis is the process of continuously regenerating yourself. Components change but the system's organization stays the same. V. was certain that, as a body, she was an autopoietic machine—a living creature. This wasn't enough for her. Was she, V., autopoietic?

¹⁷ According to Maturana and Varela: "An autopoietic machine is a machine organized (defined as a unity) as a network of processes of production (transformation and destruction) of components that produces the components which:

(i) *through their interactions and transformations continuously regenerate the network*

(ii) *constitute it (the machine) as a concrete unity in the space in which they (the components) exist by specifying the topological domain of its realization as such a network.*"

¹⁸ Reading *Autopoiesis and Cognition* right now had been V.'s idea. Also *Transgender Psychoanalysis: A Lacanian Perspective on Sexual Difference*, a selection which had prompted M. to start calling her a faggot. M. said that getting into a Lacan was a fast track to becoming extremely annoying. V. felt that, if she really tried, she could understand the Lacanian phallus; she agreed with M. that doing so would fundamentally warp something deep in her mind for the worse. On the other hand, she had finally started reading Georges Bataille at M.'s urging and that guy wasn't necessarily any less annoying. *I AM THE SUN*, he screamed at V. from 1927. *THE SEA IS CONTINUOUSLY JERKING OFF*.

Researching animal vision, Maturana's major insight was to analyze nervous systems as closed loops without inputs and outputs. Closed loops. His theory of perception did not include a flow of data from the world "out there" into the nervous system of the perceiving creature. The sensory organ is affected a certain way and there is a certain internal response determined by the organism's structure, which exists only with reference to itself. In this way he was able to comprehensively map the color spaces of several kinds of small animals. This insight became fundamental to Maturana's worldview.

To V. it was viscerally important to decide whether or not the self as she understood it was autopoietic. She could say two things: her body was autopoietic, and probably her experience of being an observer, too. Even if she dissociated or dreamt, there was a field of sensory awareness which went on existing. But was that autopoietic? Actually she wasn't sure. And why did it matter so much? Because she had called M.'s behavior autopoietic at one point? No, it was deeper.

Maturana went a step further and began to describe living creatures in terms of "circular systems of self-reproduction"; he and Varela, as we've established, formalized the concept and named it. Autopoiesis. Once again, a closed loop: the organism as a closed network. In the dry, mathematical world of the book everything is subordinated to the preservation of the organism, every stimuli processed with an eye towards homeostasis, the magnificent unity preserved. Can't we let bears stare at sunsets in peace?

Closed loops would end their creative partnership. Varela believed in the Buddha; Maturana did not. Maturana is the best witness to this. Varela asked him:

“Humberto, do you think that there is some way in which we can reach that which is transcendent? Do you think that it is possible to experience the fundamental transcendental reality that sustains everything?” I said: “I think that that is not possible according to our nature as molecular autopoietic systems.”

Varela thought it was possible. How dreary, Maturana’s world.¹⁹ She hated Maturana and she was deeply fond of him. He was funny, too. Varela and he could not agree on the social implications of autopoiesis and therefore omitted a planned appendix which would discuss the same; Maturana, receiving from Varela the “privilege” of writing the introduction to their joint work, decided to preface that work with some pages about what he would have written in the abandoned appendix. And yet this mildly hubristic aside is where Autopoiesis and

¹⁹ Everyone is always doing this, calling Maturana dreary. Danilo Zolo called his worldview a “desolate theology.” She was on the fence, but she felt protective of Maturana. He was a sweet guy!

Cognition comes closest to singing. As you've read in lightly modified form:

...there are certain experiences that cannot be fully specified in a human society without destroying the basic individual structural plasticity needed for the establishment of consensual domains and the generation of language and, hence, for human creativity in general. Love is one of those experiences, and as long as man has a language he can become an observer through the experience of love.

30 August 2023

She wasn't sure who she was writing for anymore (except M.), but she was pretty sure the self was not autopoietic.²⁰ She and M. had discussed it briefly. Maturana and Varela emphasized a sudden, complete fullness to autopoiesis; furthermore autopoiesis was continuous for the life of the entity. Her self did not feel sudden and complete. It felt effortful and fitful. Certain kinds of intentional

²⁰ Maturana agreed but at this point she didn't give a shit what that guy thought. What was it about Maturana that made her insane? She *liked* him.

behavior clearly had the aim of maintaining autopoiesis—fleeing danger, for example—but that was in an abstract sense.²¹ She didn't try to make her heart beat or her cells maintain their boundaries. She was allegedly a Buddhist and felt a little embarrassed. No-self. Duh. One way of looking at “the whole point” of mindfulness practice as she understood it was to disrupt the perceived continuity of selfhood.²²

She did not think her sensory field was autopoietic either. M. had mentioned this definition for the self, which V. thought was pretty good:

Like something coming out of nothing, the subjective self is, in effect, a constitutive absence for the sake of which new constitutive absence is being incessantly evolved.

²¹ This was her least favorite part of Maturana and Varela. Over and over again: *the purpose of cognition is to preserve autopoiesis. The organism is a closed system in which all behavior is subordinated to the preservation of autopoiesis.* Once again. Bears, sunsets. And fucking, for that matter. She hadn't talked about fucking in a while. Why not. Throw it in there. It was just like this Taiwanese rom-com she was watching (*You Are the Apple of My Eye*).

Yes, she understood that staring at sunsets and having sex could be framed in terms of the preservation of autopoiesis. If she went through life thinking that way, she thought, she might as well go ahead and end her own autopoiesis, even if just to spite Maturana and Varela.

²² She was delighted to have a Francisco Varela voice in her head. She thought he was the cutest. She wanted a Francisco Varela tattoo. Anyway, he said: “It is less of a disruption and more of a release.” She had been reading a lot of Maturana—fucking sick of that guy—and this morning she had finally started reading Varela's stuff—*The Embodied Mind*, his late-in-life (he died too young) bridging of Buddhism and cognitive science.

What is doing the evolving? She supposed you could get weird and esoteric and claim that a constitutive absence could generate itself, but she thought that was silly. Autopoiesis is about concrete networks of interrelated processes. And why get weird and esoteric when the obvious answer is right there? The workings of the organism evolve the field of awareness/subjective self. Maybe a constitutive absence can, in theory, autopoietically generate itself; even if it could, it would be a secondary autopoiesis, both conceptually and temporally. To her, it made much more sense to subordinate her subjective experience to the grand autopoiesis of her flesh and concern herself primarily with that. No separation between subjective experience and embodiment. She felt like she was saying obvious things but it was nice to work it out.

That made “V.” an *allopoietic* machine, one that existed as a contingent product of something else, like a car. She thought that was fine. Cars are useful. Beautiful, even. And V. was an interesting kind of allopoietic machine: she participated in the history of the autopoiesis which engendered her. She could make choices and fall in love and determine the shape of her structural coupling with her environment. She could establish consensual domains. She thought of something M. said: the virtuality of the body was like a “living, active ground beneath the locus of self.” You can fall on the ground. It doesn’t go away.

III. EVERY ACT OF KNOWING BRINGS FORTH A WORLD

2 September 2023

She dreamt of a battlefield and she dreamt of M. In one dream she saw artillery shells explode and bodies fly and talked to someone who was providing targeting data for a cruise missile; in another M. kissed her gently, on the neck, illuminated by soft white light. The kiss lingered as a phantom sensation well into the afternoon. Dreams can be more beautiful than reality—in memory the sensation of the kiss was contemporaneous with that of M.'s gaze and M. smiling tenderly, just for her.

Why did it make her feel sad? Even just in a dream, she thought, the kiss had come too late. Obsession had faded away—cooled? What does obsession cool to?

It made her melancholic to imagine a world where M. actually kissed her.

6 September 2023

She wasn't pregnant. She would never be pregnant.²³ This fact was usually unremarkable but it was Wednesday, she was peaking hormonally, and she was cycling off of progesterone this week. It was pseudo-science but this moment always came when she stopped taking progesterone: general malaise, melancholy, lugubriousness, mutely on the verge of tears all day—and then a gentle, spontaneous revelation: *I'm not pregnant*. Based on her understanding of menstruation V. was pretty sure that every once in a while she was inducing in herself the feeling of not being pregnant. Specifically the feeling of not being pregnant after an interval which was—she was so sorry—pregnant with the possibility.

It followed then that for a majority of the time she was inducing the feeling of being pregnant, or at least pregnant-adjacent. On the hormonal precipice of pregnancy. She liked to think of millions of trans women on progesterone, all of them radiating pregnant woman energy.²⁴ “I think you're addicted to feeling like a pregnant woman,”

²³ She was aware of the theoretical (and imminently practical) reality of uterus transplants. She found it fucking terrifying.

²⁴ Millions of trans women on progesterone is probably a very high figure, some might say “unlikely” or “implausible.” A girl can dream, you know? Achieving the existence of millions of trans women is what communism is all about! She thought of that inane Matthew Yglesias book, *One Billion Americans*. She found that objectionable. One billion trans women, on the other hand...

J. had told her once. Well, she liked feeling like a pregnant woman more than she liked not feeling like a pregnant woman. What's the point of anything when your progesterone levels are crashing?

IV. SOONER OR LATER THE SYSTEM ALWAYS KICKS BACK

22 September 2023

They met at their usual place—sort of like the Platonic ideal of a Mexican restaurant with 4.5 stars and one \$ on Google maps—for lunch. V. had been workshopping this moment. M. sat down across from her.

“Can I tell you,” V. began, “an anecdote from my life which I think will amuse you?”

M. nodded eagerly.

“I was walking through the kitchen and I saw some of J.’s tea—she’s gotten really into this weird tea with magic mold in it that cures vaping, they did an experiment where they made mice vape and then drink this tea and the mice that drank the tea had better lungs—in a pot and it reminded me of ayahuasca and I was like, this is ayahuasca, this is going to give me like, a psychedelic experience. And I was happy about that psychedelic experience even though it wasn’t there. And I

thought—in the moment, not retroactively!²⁵—*this is just like Spinoza says in Part III, Proposition XVI of his Ethics*. Which says that if you see something and you imagine it is similar to another thing, you will feel pain and pleasure like you do about that other thing, but it comes to you by the first thing as an indirect cause.”

M. smiled and smiled. Later, thinking and writing about M. smiling, V. contemplated committing every proposition in the *Ethics* to memory by means of a mental palace.²⁶

²⁵ This she did with a finger pointing Italian-ly upward and a serious look, eyebrows raised.

²⁶ As she wrote this she realized she had suggested yoga three different times—different kinds of yoga, in different ways—but still the fact remained that she averaged one yoga proselytization every 20 minutes. M. had been talking about feeling out of control—her control surfaces all fucked up. V. felt like her control surfaces were all fucked up too, and she felt useless, as she often did, when confronted with the task of supportive presence. So ... yoga?

If there was one distinct ethical belief V. could credibly claim to have embodied in daily practice, it would be *I want as many people as possible doing yoga*. She considered herself some kind of religious radical as far as yoga was concerned. M. was the administrator (some might say “charismatic center”) of a big Discord and for a while they had joked about turning it into a yoga cult. V. didn’t want a cult but she didn’t see what the issue would be with engineering widespread adoption of yoga. She had a very good time telling her yoga lady friends about the disaffected young communists she knew, questing for answers, fertile ground for yoga to take root. She imagined that one day she would feel less bad about dying if in life she had been sufficiently zealous about yoga.

*BUILDING AND DWELLING IN
WORLDS WITHOUT GROUND*

I. NOTHING MAKES ITSELF

15 November 2023

She had been Valentina when she started writing this; she was Veronica now. Things had changed with M., too. They were best friends now.²⁷

M. had withdrawn emotionally around the end of September with no explanation. V. had sensed it and gotten sad. She hadn't wanted to keep writing. She had been disappointed beyond the literary implications, of course. V. wanted to feel close to M. She wanted her as a friend. She wanted to share some emotional feedback loops.²⁸ She wanted to love M., and she wanted M. to love her. Like if Socrates and Diotima were lesbians. Or if Alcibiades weren't a really pathetic figure.²⁹

She didn't have written records anymore because they had switched to Snapchat. M. had said something like—*I tried to maintain a certain closeness with you and I got scared*. V. replied that she had noticed it,

²⁷ V.'s grandmother had been reading this. She approvingly described it—from its very first pages—as overwhelmingly adolescent. V. did feel adolescent. It was such a tired thing to say but she just did. She had never had a girl best friend in a non-tortured way. She beamed the first time M. said “best friend.” It made her very happy.

²⁸ She fretted often about the state of M.'s nervous system.

²⁹ She felt Greco-Roman about M. She had constructed an idol for herself—M. was radiant, overflowing, she wanted to admire her for admiration's sake, admire her as a way into the Good. Part of her would have launched a thousand ships for M. When she idolized M. this way she grew uneasy. She thought of the real M., the one who didn't glow, the one who held her hand and leaned her head against V.'s shoulder; the beleaguered person V. sought to care for.

been saddened by it and assumed it was her fault, was grateful for the explanation. “ily,” she appended.³⁰

“I love you too,” M. had replied (this was etched into memory, she could quote), “and I would like to please specify a mode of relationship like that if you want to.”

18 November 2023

She and M. went to Ulta. This was a departure for V. After a halfhearted attempt at the beginning of her transition, she had essentially abandoned most forms of womanly artifice. *The fat on my face has re-arranged itself*, she said to herself. *And thus I feel beautiful.*

Sometimes V. felt beautiful; oftentimes she did not. Either way, she usually didn’t try. Her mother had been like this as long as she could remember—naturally beautiful, apparently repelled by the idea of appearing that way. She was her mother’s child and furthermore she was a trans woman. Pitfalls abounded. She was avoidant of her figure. She preferred formlessness; assuming a womanly shape felt like a squeeze, a dissociation. She had to close her mind’s eye and move across a chasm. Having done so she felt like she was carrying out a fraud.

³⁰ This author is not afraid to explain things that are obvious to Zoomers. She looks beyond her obvious audience and believes in a world where people of all ages want to know about the power of Platonic trans lesbianism. Anyway, “ily” is short for “I love you.”

She had worn a slutty halloween costume to a party for the first time recently and drawn the persistent attention of a man. She had seen herself in a mirror—seen the curves that were there—she could see in the abstract the shape of woman that he was seeing and transparently responding to. It sat uncomfortably. During yoga she inhabited her body in an ungendered way. She attended to her body's structure, to pure intensities of sensation. Breathing and musculature. Gesture. Maybe the only honest bodily communication she could offer this man was to strike him; she could not comfortably embody womanhood for him. Could not comfortably embody it for anybody.³¹

She wanted to relate to her body in a less tortured manner. She wanted to relate to her body as a tool user. Techniques and technologies; *la geste et la parole*. At the very root of all her woes here was the life-negation of the depressive. She was gripped by pseudo-Buddhist reasoning about impermanence. *This body will grow old and die. What's the point?* Life flowed through her. It could flow into her hands and fingertips, animate a gesture in the direction of beauty. She wanted to want to feel beautiful. Hence Ulta with M.³²

³¹ Committing all this to the page she thought *God, here's the fascist in my head spouting toxic garbage all over the place*. She felt like a fraud! Conservative talking points.

³² Actually M. was the cause of all of this; recently she had asked if V. wanted to see her daily makeup routine. *A daily makeup routine*, V. thought, *is perplexing to me. And yet M. does it. I should think about this*. Here she thought of something M. had said recently: according to Lacan, the hysteric's position is "tell me who you think I am and I'll be that."

J. equally or more important in all of this; she had suggested directly that perhaps a more intentional performance of gender might alleviate some of the depression which swamped their emotional and personal lives.

Outside the store M. offered her a weed pen, asking if she wanted some social anxiety. V. did. Wandering the aisles in a stoned haze, she mostly deferred to M. and picked out a few products herself. The store felt massive, industrial. She felt her doomer Buddhism return, tinged with Bataille. *Look at this gleaming monument to expenditure. Enabling at an enormous scale the entirely pointless desire for more beauty.* She wondered how many people had died in terror while she wavered between two eyeshadow palettes. She was so depressed it was unreal; it was ruining her writing with pedestrian sentiment. She spent about \$120 to replicate M.'s daily makeup routine.

She did not remember much about M. from this sequence—she was lost in her own mind. Her face would be changing. She had never contoured before. As M. worked on her face she stared off into internal space and focused on the sensations of her face. When M. was done she felt almost entirely abstracted in consideration of her face. She looked at it in one mirror and then another; this lighting and that one. Her face was different—rounder, smoother. Her eyes were heightened; big and green and dramatic.

It didn't cure her depression, but it felt like something. It was faintly like watching M. load a magazine. She wanted the same fluency of gesture. She wanted to shed her self-identification with the term "frumpy lesbian." Makeup was another way of articulating desire—the desire to be beautiful—with the hands. She wanted hands well-versed in desiring.

30 November 2023

It had been so long since she wrote. She wasn't writing at all. She was so fucking depressed.

On the Discord somebody asked M.: “are you a third world maoist?” M. replied “I am a girl of many interests and fascinations.”³³ A girl of many interests and fascinations. That was for sure. Self-pityingly, V. thought of Joan Baez. *I am a girl of constant sorrow*, she thought to herself, *and this is so pathetic. It is so pathetic to be writing this*. How did M. manage to have something like a working brain? Recently she had sent V. a video of her new scientific instrument, one which V. dimly understood. It was some kind of electrical probe; it depicted waveforms. In this appreciation of a new scientific instrument M. seemed to inhabit a universe entirely different from V.'s. She could not really imagine being excited about a new scientific instrument. She couldn't imagine being excited about much of anything.

She thought again of her hands. What kind of desire animates the hands when they work a machine like that? M. wanted a machine with which to understand things—M. was a machine for understanding things.³⁴ Understanding produced by desire coupled to technique. M. did not seem to have a hard time desiring. These days V. seemed not to desire anything. Most of the time she had nothing to say at all to

³³ This question was prompted by M. describing the time she visited a Bucee's with her mother and raged against the inanity of empire.

³⁴ She had been reading *Anti-Oedipus*. Sorry.

anyone. She had been reading the *Tao Te Ching*: “I am like an idiot, my mind is so empty.”

She was writing directly for M. She wanted her to know this. She felt absent; she felt dead. There was a mode of engagement with M. and the world which she desired and which felt inaccessible, mute, blocked off. Mostly she felt like she sleepwalked through her life. She had been thinking recently about how right Spinoza had been to blur the lines between dreams and waking life. She felt this in an embodied way. She experienced reality like a dream. Just a series of fragments. Memories arose for no particular reason and usually took her somewhere unpleasant. Her day-to-day life was blurry and indeterminate. She thought this awareness was a fruit of mindfulness and she was like *gee, thanks, Lord Buddha*. Actually this insight, unpleasant as it was, was keeping her from suicidality—for some reason her sense that life was like a dream came coupled with a newfound belief in reincarnation. She did not think the dream would just end. She now felt sure that when she died Veronica would end and the dream would continue, and it was a trite observation but she did not want to experience the dream of bugs. Death didn’t seem like a release at all, just more of the same shit, probably worse.

She would like to have things to say. She would like to desire. She was terrified by this descent into placid, thousand-yard-stare nothingness.

13 December 2023

She had a weed pen again; she wanted to kill herself. She wanted to kill herself because she had a weed pen; she had a weed pen because she wanted to kill herself. One of the symbols suggested for autopoiesis—a poor candidate, she thought—was the ouroboros. How boring, to see yourself in the ouroboros. Self-consumption for what. Here there were a few different ouroboroses—she consumed herself every time she inhaled from the ovoid pen—5 grams in a container like a spaceship—³⁵wondrous artifact of U.S. capitalism in the 2020s.³⁶ And the more sinister ouroboros of depressive desire chasing a high. She didn't even care about her messy em-dash sentence, lazy self-referential metagesture of autofiction, what is the point of rhetoric when you want to kill yourself?³⁷ She took another hit and loathed herself. She liked the burning in her lungs. She liked to hurt herself. The pen started blinking and stopped before she was done pulling.³⁸

God, writing about herself was a fucking dead end.

³⁵ Not that this was particularly important, but this was “5 grams” of weed in the sense that it was 5 grams of cannabinoid and cannabinoid-adjacent compounds. Weed, she had naively imagined, would never become akin to American cheese, or “cheese products.” Why had she thought that? Of course this was how the de facto legalization of cannabis would occur.

³⁶ For some reason the button had a scowling face on it.

³⁷ Or not repeating yourself, for that matter.

³⁸ A very important teacher in her yoga lineage said that eventually people come to realize how integral breath is to the practice and that tends to sort out things like addiction. She struggled to be attentive to her breath. Behind her breath there was mostly sorrow and she did not like to ride it.

She needed a project. She wanted to write a book. Reading the work of Francisco Varela, she had encountered the Buddhist philosopher Nagarjuna in a very difficult book called *The Emptiness of Emptiness*. She would write a book, she thought, and she would call it *The Emptiness of the Emptiness of Emptiness*. It would—on the surface—be a kind of romantic refutation of Buddhism in epistolary form. In the alternate universe of the book, Baruch Spinoza accepts his inheritance and travels the world. He becomes embedded in contemporary Buddhist discourses. He visits with the Dalai Lama. All of this we learn in the book's first chapter, which announces itself as the preface to a book of his letters. Much of Spinoza's correspondence has been lost to time—the paper trail begins close to the end of his life. He is embittered, alone, obsessed with skepticism. He has misunderstood Nagarjuna and fallen into nihilism. Friends write to him; he will only engage in philosophical discussions of emptiness. Silently underneath the disputation we see the contours of their relationships—a hypothetical scenario is freighted with clearly emotional detail, an academic description of loving-kindness lurches with pathos. Sometimes joy, too. They remind him of when he was less Kierkegaardian (in the universe of the book, it is heavily suggested that Kierkegaard ultimately was plagiarizing Spinoza)—when he had friends in a more straightforward way.

Spinoza is intransigent. Terrible things start to happen. Supernatural themes are introduced; like the Buddha, Spinoza can conjure and manipulate ice. He battles with demons. He battles with emptiness, within and without.

She would put her secrets into these stories. She would put her secrets into these stories and no one, not even M., would understand all of them. She was tired of writing about reality. She couldn't do it any more. Not like she had been. She thought of Nabokov's *modus operandi* for autofiction: "...I so shuffle, twist, mix, re chew, and rebelch everything, add such spices of my own and impregnate things so much with myself that nothing remains of the autobiography but dust—the kind of dust, of course, which makes the most orange of skies."

She wanted to impregnate things with herself. Didn't Deleuze talk about impregnating his influences? She was just like Gilles.

II. THE DISPENSABILITY OF TELEONOMY

26 December 2023

For Christmas M. gave her a cactus inside a Buddha's head, 3D-printed. It protruded, bulbous, from the jade container. "I hope it makes you think of a brain," she said. It did make her think of a brain. It made her think about ayahuasca, too. She had seen 4-dimensional cacti on ayahuasca, golden and flowing into themselves in a space outside of space, and felt the presence of a terrible reptilian intelligence. She thought maybe she had done ayahuasca just so M.'s gift could remind her of it. Love and holy terror growing from the Buddha's skull. The cactus would outgrow the Buddha and one day she would have to crack him open.³⁹

She spent the night at M.'s; they slept in the same bed, holding each other.⁴⁰

³⁹ She thought of Simondon—the existence of a technical object is proof that somebody, somewhere, had experienced the pleasure of solving its problem space. She prized the Buddha because it was proof that M. had thought of her. She liked being a term in M.'s problem-solving. She liked that M. wanted to solve the problem "Christmas gift for V."

⁴⁰ Ostensibly she was there for the sake of M., who was having a very hard time—and she *was* there for M., but also she was there for herself, because being around M. soothed her, acute psychological distress or no. She was happy that being around M. soothed her. It made things simple. She thought of Vita Sackville-West— "I am reduced to a thing that wants [to hang out with] M." She wasn't frequently reduced to such a thing, but she was reducible to such a thing. She was no good at moderation. M. would hate this, but her description of Lacan's hysteric was stuck in V.'s head. On some level—certainly at the level of self-conception—she was happiest when defining herself with reference to someone definite. It was her enneagram-six-nature.

1 January 2024

She was rewiring Eurydice, her pink Jazzmaster, with the traditional rhythm circuit. It was a symbolic first step in her journey towards mastery of surf rock.⁴¹ She had chosen her first electric guitar with the intention of forming a mystical bond with the instrument and shaping her playing and musical development according to its virtues. She hadn't made a very honest start. *Leo Fender wanted this to be a blues and jazz guitar, she thought, and therefore I can get this and continue playing jazz and blues, which I already like.* Now, let us be clear: the Jazzmaster is a superlative jazz and blues guitar. But one must reckon with surf rock. And so in 2024 she would listen to a lot of surf rock and produce at least one surf rock song, no matter how bad.

She was always doing the same thing. M. had been reading her creative writing senior thesis—what V. termed her “grand cynical achievement.” 45 pages, straining to be Nabokov and Kafka and Didion, but all shot through with her tortured relationship to Yale: *I go to Yale, here's an essay written in exemplary 21st century Yale MFA modes, I hate this, you should hate this, and you should kill me.*⁴² On some level she loved to be implicated in a dynamic like that. That had been her relationship to masculinity, too.

⁴¹ She had picked up the word “journey” from her couples therapist and therefore she had to say it like a very nice gay guy.

⁴² She was softening on the piece, largely at M.'s insistence. She wouldn't write it again the same way, but nor could she, and it was an enormous effort, emotional and otherwise. She remembered writing a section about her dad and having a panic attack in a coffee shop.

Her relationship to surf rock was much more pleasant—the same formula with rounded edges and warmer colors. She felt faintly ridiculous engaging in forms of artistic production that she understood as distinctly American—which was just about all the forms of artistic production she engaged in. It wasn't *really* for her, but what else was there? So it was funny to devote herself to surf rock. It reenacted and defanged alienation. In her mind she was always just outside of these forms of art. As she wrote this it struck her how captive she was to normative conceptions. She understood that the terms of the problem were wrong. She understood there were different answers, though she wasn't quite sure what they were. But she enjoyed the problem. She enjoyed these wriggling terms, the laughing immigrant semi-sardonically getting away with something. She thought that behind her laughter, when she laughed like this, she heard derangement and the void.

Anyway. Soldering was a pain in the ass. Her soldering iron kept turning off, alternating between error messages that didn't make any sense. She had managed still to make all the connections, with solder or otherwise, and the guitar wasn't making any fucking noise. She supposed M. must feel this way frequently—pacing around the house thinking about why electrons weren't flowing as they should. She had followed the diagram!⁴³

⁴³ Writing paragraphs like this she thought of Sun Kil Moon's "This Is My Dinner." *Local woman learns to solder. It's hard. Who cares?*

APPENDIX A: *METHODOLOGY*

Influences and Approach

Many of the book's influences are obvious and explicitly named in the text; this section is devoted to the books that did not make it in but were fundamental to its creation. In essence, this book is about desire as a generative force; more specifically, it is about a *non-cathartic* relationship to desire. The thesis is that the impulse to romantic love should not necessarily always be followed to its consummation. It's not so bad to love someone from afar with no intention of closing the distance; in fact, this kind of unrequited desire can be powerful material for the autopoiesis of an integrated self out of the rubble of trauma. It can be pleasant.

The NeuroAffective Relational Model of Trauma (NARM)

NARM is something with which, if you are traumatized, you should probably familiarize yourself. "Self-regulation," according to the NARM approach,

means that when we are tired we can sleep, and when we are stressed we have healthy ways to release that stress. Affect regulation involves how we manage our emotions: how we handle sadness, joy, anger, excitement, challenge, fear—the gamut of human emotions. Symptoms of emotional dysregulation develop when we are unable to feel our emotions, when they overwhelm us, or when they remain unresolved. It is essential to our well-being to be able to manage the intensity of both our positive and negative emotions.

Affect regulation is key. NARM is a fundamentally somatic, embodied approach. Such an approach to trauma is as old as Sigmund Freud. One of his students, Wilhelm Reich, sought “to anchor in the body Freud’s belief in the biological foundation of the psyche.” He “believed that our biologically based emotions govern our psychological processes.”

In Reich’s approach, and in many subsequent approaches, the emphasis was on *cathartic release*. Patients were encouraged to identify their feelings of pain, anger, and grief and embody and articulate them intensely. Reich believed that a certain kind of orgasm could cure all or most neurosis. He asked his patients to undress and pressed “hard” on their musculature,

seeking to activate and release trauma and activate “the orgasm reflex.”⁴⁴

This is risky business. Recent clinical experience suggests that

intensely cathartic affective interventions can have the unintended effect of causing increased fragmentation and re-traumatization. Focusing on the pain, emptiness, or rage caused by early loss, neglect, or trauma does not in itself lead to healing.

As an alternative,

The orientation in the NARM approach is to use mindful awareness to help the client tolerate strong emotion, neither acting it out against the environment nor directing it against the self. Rather than being discharged through catharsis, powerful emotional and energetic states are contained so that they can be integrated and transformed into an increased capacity for connection. Mindfully staying present to and

⁴⁴ None of this is to say that Wilhelm Reich was not, in many ways, intensely cool. He was a socially-engaged Marxist and, for all his errors, fundamentally ahead of his time. In my humble opinion.

containing intense affect increases nervous system resiliency and supports the development of emotional depth.

It is hopefully clear now that this book is a work of self-therapy.

GRAVEYARD/DUM SPIRO SPERO

24 August 2023

V. caught COVID at that party she was so worked up about. Delirious and exhausted when confronted with the page. She shouldn't even be writing. She had written the word "she" 206 times. One good thing about writing in the third person, she thought, is that you get to write the word "she" a lot.⁴⁵ It was like fairly unsubtle therapy. The whole book was like fairly unsubtle therapy. She had an Appendix about the NeuroAffective Relational Model (NARM) of trauma.

She waved goodbye to M. for a bit—the object of her affection was busy soldering things onto a circuit board and she was busy writing, didn't have the time to be consumed with chastely yearning, etc. Would the reader forgive her? At any rate she would soon be writing much more for M. than for anyone else, even more so than for you.

7 June 2023

There had been another exchange:

V: Are you into me? I'm into you but a negative answer wouldn't make me less interested in being friends.

⁴⁵ She realized that this rhetorical device would almost vanish upon translation into Spanish—was essentially untranslatable.

Asking this in the preliminary way which our relatively limited acquaintance permits

M: Honestly hard for me to give a coherent answer. Emotions like that are very loose and slow for me and hard to process immediately. also the prospect of seeing other people has only come up in passing so it would have to be something I would talk to my girlfriends about even if I knew you well enough to know yet

IV. IN A CLOSED SYSTEM, INFORMATION TENDS TO DECREASE AND HALLUCINATION TO INCREASE

23 August 2023

M. read the first 22 pages of a draft of the book. V. had been so flustered.

V: well, if this makes things weird it makes things weird

you're welcome to correct factual errors

i hope it's clear that this is like a philosophical working
out and there's not a 1:1 to like, my actual set of
coherent feelings about you i guess

but it's all pretty truthful at the same time

M: i want to put more thought into a full response

i don't think it does

i want us to nurture a long term relationship

Then M. added her on Snapchat.⁴⁶

A mere “philosophical working out,” huh? Coward. She thought about
something else John Gall said:

THE SYSTEM IS ALTERED BY THE PROBE USED TO
TEST IT. THE PROBE IS ALTERED ALSO.

She was still waiting on the fuller response and though she very much
desired M.'s promised elaboration on her initial thoughts she didn't
feel great about saying “please hurry up your response to my writing

⁴⁶ *It is the year 2023, she thought, and Snapchat features prominently in my
attempt at autofiction. In fact the autofiction would not exist if not for Snapchat.*

about being obsessed with you.” And, anyway, the initial thoughts were clear enough if she could get past her intense neuroticism.

The book was changing as she lived it. Who would have thought. That was fine: she didn’t think she had much more obsession left in her. Of course she wasn’t done with desire. But the obsession, she thought, had perhaps been transmuted. Or she had been transmuted by obsession. Tuning in to her feelings about M. now revealed something like placidity and gently humming desire.⁴⁷ Obsession

21 August 2023

When she wrote like this she felt newly born as an eye.⁴⁸ She had forgotten the feeling. TKTKTK

13 September 2023

Horselover Fat needed to get off dope and quit trying to help people;⁴⁹ she needed to stop smoking weed and quit getting obsessed with people. Actually she felt rather like Horselover Fat. She saw herself in

⁴⁷ She did feel a faint sense of artistic dread. She thought of Hegel: “History is not the soil in which happiness grows. The periods of happiness in it are the blank pages of history.” What is the narrative structure of romantic desire that is swimming along? She wasn’t sure.

⁴⁸ “My Bataille-pilled answer,” M. had told her once, “is that you need to have a more honest relationship with death.”

⁴⁹ Horselover Fat is a character from the Philip K. Dick novel *Valis*, which I also was reading because of M. It’s me, the author. I address you directly when it comes to matters like these. Hi.

Anyway, Horselover Fat is this frequently suicidal guy who thinks that God shot a pink beam full of information straight into his brain. He had a vision of his son’s potentially fatal birth defect and ancient Greek spontaneously came to his lips. He believed that a divine satellite orbited the Earth.

him locking himself away so he could write his grand explanation of reality.